

Use LimeSurvey for an Extraordinary Surveying Experience

LimeSurvey is a premier online, open source tool that is downloaded thousands of times every week by individuals, companies and universities to conduct various types of surveys.

LimeSurvey helps to set up surveys or questionnaires with a click of the mouse and the minimum of technical knowledge. According to Wikipedia, LimeSurvey "...is a Web server-based software. It enables users to develop and publish online surveys and collect responses, without doing any programming." It is written in PHP and requires a database (MySQL, PostgreSQL, etc) to function. LimeSurvey was initiated by Carsten Schmitz, and is now available in its stable release 2.05 under the GNU General Public License.

Striking features

LimeSurvey offers exceptionally good features. As a surveying tool, it has everything that you'll ever want. Here are some of the features provided by LimeSurvey:

- Multiple surveys at a time
- No limit to the number of questions
- Grouping of questions
- 20+ types of questions
- User profile management
- Unlimited participants
- Support for 70+ languages
- Token-based survey participation
- Support for printer-friendly version of surveys
- The capability to add images in surveys
- Multiple themes and support for WYSIWYG HTML Editor

Pre-requisites

LimeSurvey is compatible with Linux-based systems as well as with Microsoft Windows platforms. For this article, I will demonstrate a Windows installation to keep things simple. LimeSurvey is server-based software and hence requires a Web server to run on the hosting machine. Also, a database like MySQL, PostgreSQL or



MS SQL is required. To set up a basic working environment, I would recommend installing the WAMP server on your machine, which is a complete development environment for Web applications and hence includes Web server (Apache) and database applications (MySQL).

You can download WAMP from <http://sourceforge.net/projects/wampserver/files/WampServer%202/WampServer%202.0/WampServer2.0i.exe/download>

Make sure that after the installation of the WAMP server, you have the directory `c:\wamp` and the access to it. I am assuming that you have a working WAMP server installed.

Installation

- Download the latest stable release of the LimeSurvey from the following link: <http://www.limesurvey.org/en/stable-release>
- Unzip the contents of the .zip file you downloaded, to the folder `C:\wamp\www\LimeSurvey`.
- The installation part is done. Just start the WAMP server (*Start menu->start wampserver*).
- Using any Web browser, go to <http://localhost/> and LimeSurvey should be listed under *Your Projects*.
On its first run, LimeSurvey needs certain parameters to be set up. Follow the steps shown below:
 - Go to <http://localhost/LimeSurvey>, which will open up